Fiche de correction

Passing the Flame. Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion.

Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac

Specialism LLCER English · Terminale of the lycée général et technologique

Programme of BO spécial n° 8 of 25 July 2019: thematic areas « Arts et débats d'idées » and « Expression et construction de soi » (axis « Mise en scène de soi »). Level C1.

Model answers, grids and indicated standards for the ten lessons, the midpoint commentary and the summative tasks.

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These are model answers and indicated standards, not the only acceptable scripts. A student who argues a different thesis with accurate quotation and formal attention may outwrite a model.

Lesson 1. Diagnostic

Question. « What does it mean, in the theatre, to read between the lines, and why might that courage also be dangerous? » (180-220 words.)

Indicated standard. A strong script distinguishes seeing, interpreting and knowing. It takes at least one precise element from the video (a named person, a gesture, a bilingual edition) or from Chassériau (a pictorial fact) and already anticipates that a spectator may know too much, or may enjoy knowing. It does not retell the video.

A model (about 200 words).

To read between the lines, in the theatre, is not to invent a secret. It is to notice what a line does not say, what a pause holds, and what one character hears that another does not mean. The courage in that attention is real: without it, Iago's plain words would pass as service, and a painting such as Chassériau's Venetian interior would be treated as a mere illustration of a plot. The video essay, in remembering Professor Pierre Spriet opening a bilingual edition with care, offers the same discipline in another form: a way of listening that honours two languages and refuses haste.

The danger is equally real, and this sequence will not let it go. A spectator who reads between the lines holds a surplus of knowledge. That surplus can become pride. If we are not careful, we shall enjoy Iago's confidence, in the first scene, as a privilege, and we shall forget that the play is about to make such a privilege fatal. To read between the lines is therefore a moral as well as a technical act: it asks us to see, to interpret, and to remain unsure about what we know.

Emergency exit, a possible three sentences. The video remembers a teacher opening a bilingual book. That gesture suggests that reading is a form of respect, not a hunt for a single key. The question I wish to keep open is whether a spectator can know more than a character and still remain humble.

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Lesson 2. The contract of « I am not what I am »

Indicated standard. The paragraph treats the line as a pact with the audience, notices the refusal to wear the heart on the sleeve, and at least mentions the theatrical consequence (dramatic irony, complicity). The biblical inversion may be noted; it should not swallow the reading.

A model opening (students may finish differently). Iago's last clause is not a riddle offered to Roderigo alone. It is a profession, spoken before Othello has appeared, that teaches the spectator how masks will be worn. By treating sincerity (« wear my heart upon my sleeve ») as a feast for fools, Iago flatters us into preferring his cold knowledge. The trap begins when we enjoy that preference.

Emergency exit. (1) I declare that my visible self is not my actual self. (2) The spectator now shares a knowledge that Othello does not share. (3) The privilege is not safe, because it may make us proud, and because we may be used as Iago uses Roderigo.

Lesson 3. The Senate

Question. « How does Othello, in I.3, turn his life into a story that can be heard by a court, and what does Brabantio try to plant in the same hearing? »

A model (about 180 words).

Othello does not answer Brabantio with a legal subtlety. He tells a life: a father's invitations, a daughter's « greedy ear », disasters and redemptions, and a love that grew from pity and from telling. The close is a chiasmus (« She lov'd me for the dangers I had pass'd, / And I lov'd her that she did pity them ») and a denial of witchcraft. The Senate is invited to hear testimony; the Duke's remark, that such a tale would win his own daughter, admits that the testimony is also an art. Desdemona then displaces the gaze: « I saw Othello's visage in his mind. » Seeing is taken inside, against a public language that would stop at the face.

Brabantio, defeated, plants a proverb: « Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see: / She has deceiv'd her father, and may thee. » The couplet turns a daughter's choice into a proof of future betrayal, and it teaches a use of the eyes that is already close to surveillance. Othello's pledge, « My life upon her faith », is generous; his immediate entrusting of Desdemona to « Honest Iago » is the dramaturgical cost of that generosity. What is planted in the hearing is a way of looking. The rest of the play will harvest it.

Lesson 4. Ocular proof

A model on the question « In III.3, how does Shakespeare turn the wish to know into a wish to be confirmed? » (extract).

Iago’s most effective work in III.3 is not a clear accusation. It is a re-education of looking. The warning about the « green-ey’d monster » sounds like prudence; it installs jealousy as a lens. When Othello asks, in effect, to see, he is already asking to see a particular scene. « Ocular proof » names a reasonable demand (love will not live on rumour) and a fatal one (in a theatre, and under Iago’s direction, what is shown will have been arranged). « Haply, for I am black » shows the cost in the first person: a public gaze, already heard in the Senate, is now spoken from within. The wish to know has become a wish to have a story confirmed.

Lesson 5. III.4, and the midpoint

The students' booklet already contains a full model close reading. The correction below is a model *midpoint commentary*, of the length a strong student might achieve in fifty-two minutes. It is not a transcript of the booklet's model, and it should be given out only after the attempt.

Question. « In Act III, scene 4, how does Shakespeare make a hand, a handkerchief and a change of subject into instruments of a trap of perception? »

A model commentary.

The trap of perception, in *Othello*, is not only a matter of lies told in the ear. In III.4 Shakespeare shows how a method of reading, already accepted in III.3, can seize a body, a gift and a conversation. A hand is over-read, a handkerchief is given a sacred history, and a change of subject is heard as a confession. The audience, which knows that Emilia has the cloth, watches meanings being sewn into facts that cannot answer back.

The scene opens with a short, flat lie. « Where should I lose that handkerchief, Emilia? » is an honest question; « I know not, madam » is a refused knowledge. Dramatic irony is at once moral: the first breach of trust is a silence. Desdemona still believes her husband « true of mind ». Othello enters already doubled, his courtesy cut by the aside « O, hardness to dissemble! », and he takes her hand. « This hand is moist, my lady » begins as observation and becomes, within a few lines, a diagnosis: « Hot, hot, and moist », a « young and sweating devil », a call for fasting and prayer. Early modern medicine can explain the humoral language; it cannot excuse the moralisation. Iago's method (a sign made to mean more than was intended) is here applied to flesh. Desdemona returns the hand to the wedding (« 'twas that hand that gave away my heart ») and is not heard. The sententia that follows, « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts », names the play's problem, the gap between emblem and inwardness, and uses it against her.

The handkerchief, which had been a love-token, is then given a new story: an Egyptian charmer, a sibyl, hallowed worms, mummy, « magic in the web », and perdition if the gift is lost. Whether Othello tells a family truth, intimidates, or can no longer separate the two, the dramaturgical fact is clear. He installs a meaning. The object becomes a warrant and an ordeal. Rymer, later, will mock the disproportion; the answer to Rymer is already here: the cloth is not the cause, it is the support of a forced reading. Desdemona's « Come now, your promise », her fidelity to Cassio's suit, and her hypothetical, « It is not lost, but what and if it were? », are grammatically innocent. In the new hermeneutic they weigh as proof. Othello's speech shrinks to a repeated command, « The handkerchief! », an aposiopesis that is also an order.

Emilia, at the close, sees that jealous souls are « jealous for they are jealous », that the monster is « Begot upon itself ». She still does not say where the cloth is. A hand, a gift and a change of subject have been made into instruments; the one fact that would undo the reading remains unspoken. The trap is complete not when a handkerchief is lost, but when perception has been taught to treat every remainder of love as evidence.

Emergency exit, a compact standard. Emilia lies (« I know not, madam »). Othello reads a moist hand as a devil in the palm, and as a heraldry of hands without hearts. He then binds the handkerchief with « magic in the web ». Desdemona's « what and if it were? » is heard as guilt. Emilia knows that jealousy is self-begotten and still does not speak. Trust fails three times in one scene.

Lesson 6. Othello as spectator

A model (about 180 words).

In IV.1 Shakespeare does not only tell us that Othello is deceived. He places him in the seat of a spectator and lets us watch a man watching. Iago has become a director: he withdraws Othello, tells him what the coming laughter will mean, and then plays a scene with Cassio whose referent (Bianca, a found handkerchief, a boast) is not the referent Othello has been taught to hear (Desdemona, a stolen token, a confession). Direction precedes speech. The cruelty of the construction is that Othello is given the very privilege the audience has enjoyed since « I am not what I am »: he knows, he thinks, more than the man he watches. The surplus is a lie. Theatre is no longer only the medium of the tragedy; it is the weapon inside the plot. A commentary that stops at « Othello is jealous » has not read the scene. The scene is about a way of looking that has already been arranged.

Lesson 7. Two meanings

Indicated standard for the table. At least: Bianca's entrance (a mistress arriving / a proof that the handkerchief has left a wife); the request to copy the work (an embroidery to be imitated / a token passed from woman to woman); a laugh or a dismissive phrase (Cassio's ease with Bianca / contempt for Desdemona). The commentary should conclude that ocular proof fails when the story has been assigned in advance.

Lesson 8. Light, and « Speak of me as I am »

A model (extract).

« Put out the light, and then put out the light » turns a word on itself. The first light is a lamp, which can be relit; the second is a life, which cannot. The anadiplosis is a ritualising gesture: Othello tries to make a killing sound like a justice or a sacrifice. The verse does not leave him that comfort without resistance: Desdemona's voice, her confusion, her innocence, crack the rite. At the end, « Speak of me as I am. Nothing extenuate, / Nor set down aught in malice » is a request for a just report and, at the same time, a last act of self-fashioning. The pearl, the service to the state, the stroke in Aleppo, the kiss: Othello supplies the images by which he wishes to be remembered. He is still, in a new way, directing a spectator, now a future reader of Venice's letters. The crux « Judean » / « Indian » (Gutenberg 1531 reads the first) is a reminder that even the last simile is not entirely in his, or our, control.

Lesson 9. Answering the critics, and Hugo

Answering Rymer (a model paragraph). Rymer is right to be astonished that a handkerchief should bear so much weight, and wrong about the reason. The play is not the tragedy of an accessory, and it is not a bloody farce because a cloth is involved. The cloth is the object onto which a method of reading, taught in III.3 and applied in III.4, has been forced. To see only the object is to repeat, in criticism, the very literalism the tragedy exposes.

Answering Coleridge (a model paragraph). « The motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity » names something real: Iago's reasons (promotion, a rumour, hatred) are offered and never quite account for the energy of the harm. The phrase becomes too absolute, however, if it turns Iago into a metaphysical principle. The hunting of motives is itself a performance, consistent with « I am not what I am ». We may keep Coleridge's sharpness without letting the phrase do all the work.

Hugo, indicated observations. A good student paragraph will (1) quote the English last clause, (2) quote Hugo's rendering accurately from the public-domain edition supplied, (3) say whether the biblical inversion survives, (4) examine the idiom of the sleeve, and (5) return to the theatrical contract: if French clarifies what English leaves as a creed, does the pact with the spectator change? There is no single correct translation-judgement; there is a correct method.

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Lesson 10. Summative commentary, a full model

Question. « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? »

A model (of the length and ambition expected at C1, slightly fuller than a fifty-two-minute script, to serve as a standard).

Shakespeare's most exact cruelty in *Othello* is not that a noble man is lied to. It is that he is placed, at the decisive moment, in the position of a spectator, and that the play has been training us, from the first scene, to occupy that same position with pleasure. To ask how Othello is made a spectator of his own deception is to ask how theatre itself, as a way of looking, becomes a trap.

The training begins in I.1. Iago's « I am not what I am » is a contract with the audience. We are taken into a confidence that Othello does not share; we are flattered by a surplus of knowledge. In I.3 that surplus has a counterpart in trust: Othello tells his life before the Senate, wins a hearing, and pledges « My life upon her faith », before leaving Desdemona to the very man who has just professed unreality. Brabantio's seed, « Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see », already names eyes as a faculty of suspicion. III.3 re-educates those eyes. Iago's warning about the green-eyed monster, Othello's « Haply, for I am black », and the demand for « ocular proof » turn the wish to know into a wish to be confirmed. III.4 applies the method to a hand and a gift. A moist palm is over-read; a handkerchief is bound with « magic in the web »; a change of subject is heard as guilt. By the time we reach IV.1, looking itself has been prepared.

IV.1 is the centre. Iago does not accuse; he directs. He withdraws Othello, instructs him in the meaning of the coming scene, and then holds a conversation with Cassio whose true referent Othello does not share. Bianca, the handkerchief as a pattern to be copied, a laugh: each fact is available to two stories. Othello, watching, believes he has at last the ocular proof he asked for. What he has is a spectacle arranged for a single spectator. Shakespeare's intelligence is to give him our privilege, corrupted. We watch a man watching, and we are made to feel, if we are honest, the danger of the surplus we have enjoyed since Act I.

The last scene does not abandon this structure. In V.2 Othello still tries to direct a gaze: he ritualises a killing with a word turned upon itself (« Put out the light, and then put out the light »), and in « Speak of me as I am » he tries to direct the report that Venice will receive. He remains, until the end, a man concerned with how a life will be seen. The guiding question of the sequence asked what the trap still teaches about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines. It teaches, at least, this humility: reading between the lines is necessary, and it can be fatal when a story has already been assigned to what we see. To explain the trap is not to stand safely outside it. It is to recognise, in the spectator we have been, the spectator Othello is forced to become.

Director's oral, an indicated standard. A strong two-to-three-minute commentary names one scene (IV.1 is the most natural, III.4 and I.1 are equally defensible), justifies one staging choice from a word or a cue in the verse (for example: Othello visible to us and badly placed to hear referents; or Emilia's « I know not » spoken too quickly, as a reflex of loyalty), and acknowledges a risk (of turning the play into a sermon on « fake news »; of making Iago charming; of flattening otherness into a single lesson). Delivery is clear, British English is controlled, and the student does not act the scene.



Flashcards, brief keys

1. I.1; a pact of knowing with the spectator. 2. A crossing of terms; « She lov'd me for the dangers… / And I lov'd her that she did pity them. » 3. « Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see… »: eyes taught as suspicion. 4. Othello's life is staked on Desdemona's faith; she is then left to Iago. 5. A seeing that refuses the face as the last word. 6. Iago; a warning that installs a lens. 7. The Senate's public language of fairness and blackness, now spoken from within. 8. For example: « Evidence that the eyes themselves can seize. » 9. « I know not, madam »: she has the cloth. 10. A humoral sign moralised into desire and guilt. 11. A proverb on gesture without inwardness, used against Desdemona's gift of her heart. 12. Lore: the diction of a family charm; intimidation: the tale rises at the moment of interrogation. 13. Because the new grammar of proof treats a

hypothesis as a confession. 14. She knows jealousy is self-begotten; she does not say she took the cloth. 15. Iago; Othello; Cassio. 16. When an assigned story and a real referent occupy the same words. 17. Anadiplosis, or a word turned: lamp, then life. 18. The report, the future image of himself. 19. Editions differ; each simile has a different force; honesty requires the uncertainty. 20. It names Iago’s inadequate reasons; it should not freeze him into a principle. 21. He sees the disproportion; he misses the forced reading. 22. « When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why? » Then one path, carefully. 23. The guiding question as printed at the front of the booklet. 24. His translation is in the public domain; the sequence does not use copyrighted French versions. 25. To keep a surplus of knowledge from becoming pride, and to leave unsettled what the play leaves unsettled.

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